a time when many other Asian economies opened up and grew. In hindsight, the 1970s and 1980s were difficult decades for India, when it was often on the defensive in international affairs.

In and around 1991, several things changed, including in terms of India's politics, security, international relations, and economy. Chapter 4: 1991–2008 describes how the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi, the Kashmir insurgency and Bombay blasts, the collapse of the Soviet Union, and a balance of payments crisis in 1991 contributed to a new phase in India's international relations. Under P.V. Narasimha Rao, India established diplomatic relations with Israel and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), initiated a Look East Policy, attempted to normalize relations with China and the United States, and explored the possibility of nuclear tests. In 1998, under Atal Bihari Vajpayee, India tested its nuclear weapons but swiftly engaged the United States and its allies, China, and Pakistan. Despite these efforts, the period after 1999 was marked by successive crises with Pakistan, including the Kargil War and a rise in cross-border terrorist activity. After 2004, under Manmohan Singh, India worked to normalize its nuclear programme and improve relations with the United States in a period of American unipolarity. This period also saw important developments in India's neighbourhood, including the end of civil conflicts in Nepal and Sri Lanka.

Despite various strides taken after 1998, the global financial crisis and other domestic and international developments in and around 2008 resulted in something of a pause, described in Chapter 5: 2008–2024. In the first five years or so after the global financial crisis, ties with the US and Europe were marked by irritants and instead India attempted to work constructively with other rising powers, such as China, as in the BRICS grouping (along with Brazil, Russia, and later South Africa). But continued diplomatic dialogue with Pakistan proved frustrating, and differences persisted with Beijing. After 2014, under Narendra Modi, India made a concerted attempt to reengage its neighbourhood and the Indian Ocean. Motivated by growing divergences with China, India consolidated its partnership with the United States and the Quad (Australia, India, Japan, and the United States) in the